

Life in King SIZE

Showcasing the extravagance of royal patronage and possessions

By Dilip Bobb



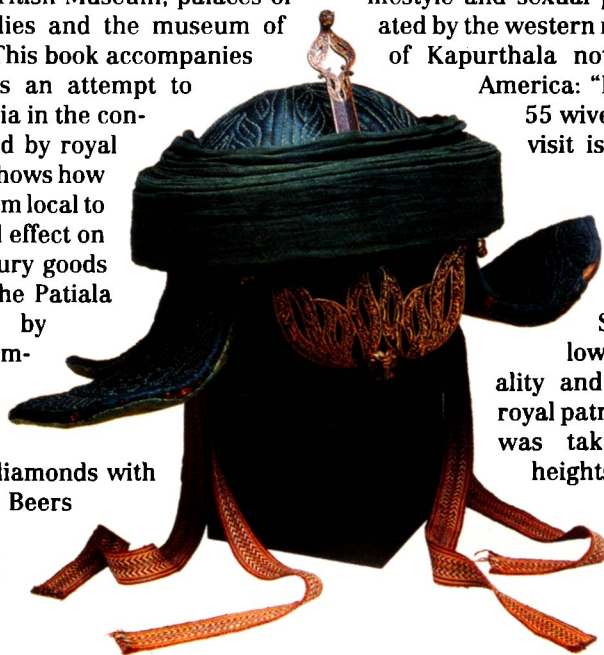
MAHARAJA: THE SPLENDOUR OF INDIA'S ROYAL COURTS

Edited by ANNA JACKSON AND AMIN JAFFER
Lustre Press
Price: Rs 2,975
Pages: 240

The Splendour of India's Royal Courts is a visual blockbuster. Rarely have the gilded trappings of Indian royalty come together under one roof to dazzle the world like they did back then. At the entrance to the exhibition is a life-sized model of an elephant draped in silver necklaces and at the end is its 20th century counterpart, a 1927 Rolls Royce Silver Phantom convertible custom-built for a royal and lovingly restored. As is the image of the maharajas and their lifestyles.

Many of the objects on display have come from private collectors, others from the v&a's own collection, the British Museum, palaces of erstwhile royal families and the museum of Islamic Art in Doha. This book accompanies the exhibition and is an attempt to define kingship in India in the context of the role played by royal patronage. It clearly shows how the patronage shift from local to global had a profound effect on the production of luxury goods in Europe. There is the Patiala necklace designed by Cartier, the largest commission ever filled by the Parisian jewellers, comprising five strands of huge diamonds with the 234.61 carat De Beers

HELMET WORN BY TIPU SULTAN



diamond as its central pendant. There is also the custom-made Cartier dressing table set made for Amarinder Singh's grandfather in silver, enamel, coral and gold. The refinement of the workmanship is truly exquisite. Works by leading jewellers like Chaumet are also especially commissioned.

Other remarkable pieces in the exhibition—and the book—is the legendary tiger claw made for Shivaji which he used so effectively on his enemies, and the stunning sword and scabbard made of steel, diamonds, emeralds, rubies made for Indore and a permanent exhibit at the v&a. There is also Tipu Sultan's helmet made of leather, quilted silk, steel and gold and Udaipur's suit of armour, a rare surviving example of the "thousand-headed" technique in which layers of textile and hide were bound together with brass rivets. Some of the most outstanding examples of craftsmanship have been sourced from the Islamic Art Museum in Doha, including a Mughal era wine flask covered in jade, emeralds and rubies. There are also palanquins and howdahs which, till Rolls Royce came along, were the most visible symbol of royal extravagance and status. There is also erotica: maharajas were notoriously virile and there is one painting showing Maharo Ram Singh of Kota pleasuring three women at the same time.

There is also the fact that much of the royal lifestyle and sexual prowess was exaggerated by the western media. As Jagajit Singh of Kapurthala noted before a visit to America: "I am supposed to have

55 wives and the object of my visit is to add an American lady to that number. I am also supposed to smoke monster cigars and drink champagne all day."

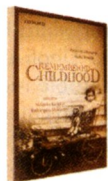
Some did, however, allow the myth to become reality and the extravagance of royal patronage and possessions was taken to extraordinary heights. If you can't catch the exhibition at the v&a (till January 17), this book is an adequate substitute. ■



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